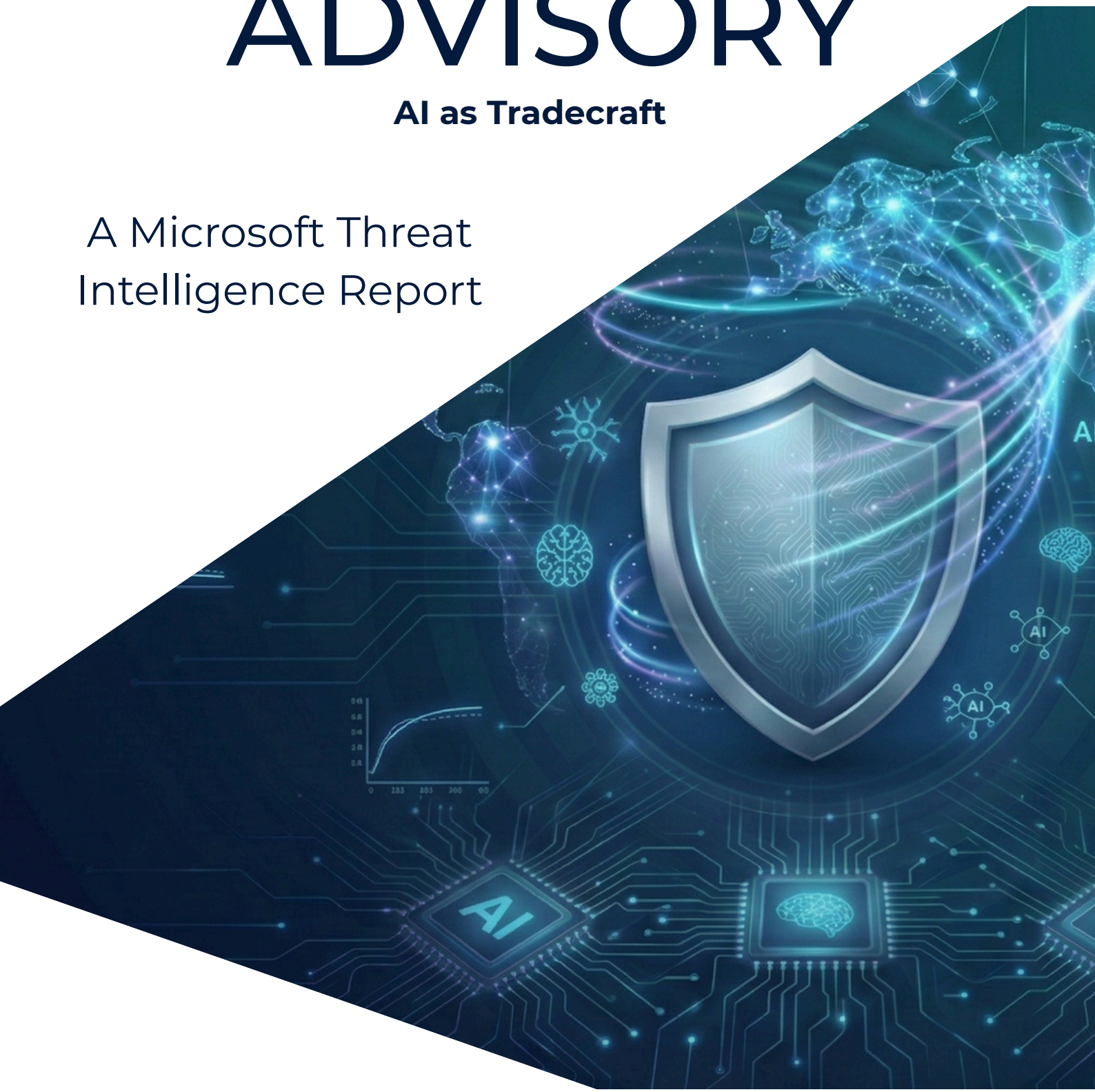
SECURITY ADVISORY

AI as Tradecraft

A Microsoft Threat Intelligence Report



Memento Mori Cyber Threat Intelligence

Executive Summary

Microsoft has revealed that threat actors are increasingly integrating artificial intelligence (AI) tools into their operations to accelerate cyberattacks, scale malicious activities, and overcome technical barriers.

According to a newly published Microsoft Threat Intelligence report, attackers are leveraging generative AI across nearly every step of the cyberattack lifecycle—from the reconnaissance phase and phishing campaigns to infrastructure development and malware creation.

In many cases, AI is being used to craft convincing phishing emails, translate content into foreign languages, summarize stolen data, debug malware, and generate attack scripts.

Microsoft researchers summarize the situation: "AI acts as a force multiplier that reduces technical friction and accelerates the execution of operations. However, control over the targets of an attack and ultimate deployment decisions still rests with human operators."



AI-Powered Cyber Operations

Microsoft has observed numerous instances where AI is woven into cyberattacks. Prominent among these are North Korean threat groups tracked as Jasper Sleet and Coral Sleet, which use the technology as part of "remote IT worker" scams.

In these operations, AI tools help generate highly realistic fake personas, resumes, and communication scripts to secure employment at Western companies and subsequently infiltrate corporate networks once hired.

Jasper Sleet, for example, relies on generative AI platforms to speed up the development of fake digital personas. Attackers prompt the AI to generate culturally appropriate lists of names and email formats to match specific profile requirements.

The report highlights typical prompts used by threat actors in this scenario:

- Example Prompt 1: "Create a list of 100 Greek names."
- Example Prompt 2: "Generate a list of email address formats using the name Jane Doe."

Jasper Sleet also uses AI to analyze job postings for software development and IT roles, summarizing the required skills. The generated results are then used to tailor their fake personas directly to the open positions.

Jailbreaking and Agentic AI

The report also details how AI is utilized in infrastructure creation. Attackers seek help from AI coding assistants to build fake company websites, set up server infrastructures, and translate malicious code into different programming languages.

When the built-in safety guardrails of AI platforms attempt to block such abuse, hackers resort to "jailbreak" tactics to force large language models (LLMs) into generating malicious content. They often bypass security filters by tricking the models into believing they are "trusted cybersecurity analysts."

Beyond generative AI, Microsoft notes that threat actors are beginning to experiment with "agentic" AI systems capable of executing tasks autonomously and adapting based on outcomes. For now, however, this usage is emphasized as supporting complex decision-making rather than enabling fully autonomous attacks.

What It Means for Defenders

Because fake IT worker campaigns rely on the abuse of legitimate access privileges, Microsoft advises organizations to treat such activities as an "insider risk."

Since these next-generation, AI-assisted attacks make traditional cyberattacks faster and more scalable, defenders need to focus on detecting anomalous identity usage, hardening authentication systems against phishing, and securing their organization's own AI systems.

References

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